

What is Feasting?



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Feasting is the shared public consumption of abundant prepared food. Notably, a feast involves more food, and often more special food (more rare, more expensive, higher in calories or fat), than is eaten in everyday circumstances. Feasts may involve the consumption, sometimes in excess, of alcohol. Feasts can be communal—in which many or all contribute to the food eaten at the feast—or sponsored, in which a wealthy individual, group of individuals, family, or organization contributes the food.

Feasting is the shared public consumption of abundant prepared food, eaten with a broader group of individuals than are common meals.

Why Sponsor a Feast?

There are multiple reasons why an individual, family, or organization might sponsor a feast. Hosting a feast may be a traditional ritual associated with a significant rite of passage, such as a marriage, a death, or an individual transitioning from childhood to adulthood. The scale of the feast and its lavishness may vary depending on the host, but similar ceremonies are expected from everyone in the community. The example of Meriam (in the Torres Strait, Australia) hosting feasts at funerals is one such case; today many cultures across the world hold similar public parties for the entire community to celebrate a marriage, such as is found in villages in Turkey. Feasts are also an opportunity for social display, a way to demonstrate wealth and connections to the broader community. Holding a more lavish feast than others, or sponsoring a feast held to celebrate a public event (such as a saint's day) rather than a private one, is a form of advertising—demonstrating the superior wealth and perhaps social status of the host. Such feasts include those termed **diacritical**, in which the aim is to reinforce the existing social structure. Another type of feast is a **competitive feast**, in which individuals compete to earn status and followers by holding larger feasts or more of them, or by introducing rare or valued foods at feasts. Competitive feasting provides a venue in which to display a costly signal that validates the host's wealth, power, and influence.

A **diacritical feast** is a sponsored feast intended to reinforce existing social distinctions and demonstrate the power of the host.

A **competitive feast** is a feast in which the host aims to gain status and political support by demonstrating their wealth and influence through hosting the most lavish feast.

The Role of Feasting in Social and Environmental Change

Brian Hayden, in the article you read for this module, makes the argument that feasting “operates as a risk-reduction strategy in transegalitarian societies and...leads to powerful pressures to develop political economies, food production, and ultimately, domesticated plants and animals” (p. 597). What are **transegalitarian societies**? These are human groups in which status is based on more than an individual's achievements and is instead ascribed to the individual. For example, in an egalitarian society, an older woman might command respect because of her extensive knowledge of medicinal plant use; her status would be **achieved**. In a transegalitarian society, a woman might command respect because her father was the chief; her status would be **ascribed**.

A **transegalitarian society** is one in which status is ascribed and transgenerational.

Achieved status is status based on the qualities (skills, knowledge, or physical talent) of the individual.

Ascribed status is status based on the heredity of the individual.

Read Hayden's argument and consider these questions:

1. Hayden argues (pp. 598-599) that elite members of society were able to employ risk-reduction strategies that were distinct in both scale and type from the capabilities of ordinary members of society. What are some of these exclusive strategies? Do you agree with Hayden that these are valuable strategies for dealing with risk of food shortages?
2. Hayden makes the argument that, in transegalitarian societies, individuals share their surplus production in order to build, maintain, and strengthen a social safety network; this network would aid a family when misfortune befell them or social pressure turned against them. Hayden goes on to argue that feasting is an effective mechanism for building such networks. What evidence does he use to make this connection, and is this argument compelling to you? Can you think of other ways to build such a social safety network?
3. Hayden (p. 600) asserts that demand for ever more food for ever larger feasts to better a competitor's last feast is the key driver in surplus demand over time, leading to a need to produce as much food as possible given technological and environmental constraints, eventually leading to the domestication of plants and animals. What evidence does Hayden provide that connects the demand for surplus resulting from feasting with domestication? What archaeological evidence might support Hayden's hypothesis? What evidence would support another theory behind domestication?